



All-round show: Recently, Hardik Pandya completed 2000 T20I runs, becoming only the fifth allrounder with the double of 2000 runs and 100 wickets in men's T20Is.

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of his spin-hitting abilities. In the slog overs in the last two years, Axar has scored at 0.27 runs per ball slower than the average batter against pace, considering game situation, line and length. He has a strike rate of 72.4 against short-of-good-length pace and 54.5 against short balls. Axar is a far better hitter of spin than of pace, scoring 0.27 runs faster than the average batter against spin, given the match situations, lines and lengths he faces. Moreover, he strikes full-length spin at a whopping 257 SR and good-length spin at 140 SR, making him an ideal batter to get some boundaries for India in the middle overs, when they have traditionally struggled to get going against the slow bowlers.

In the Nagpur T20I against New Zealand, India played both Axar and Shivam Dube. With Axar set as the spin-hitter, Dube has to walk in at seven or eight, which is suboptimal. He struggles against the 2-4 m length, scoring at 117 SR in T20Is played in India and the IPL, while the

average batter in these games hits that length at 142 SR. In addition, against the hard length (8-10 m), Dube strikes at a paltry 113 SR, while the average batter strikes at 139. Against the 0-2 m yorker length, his strike rate is 82, while the average batter goes at 119 SR. These three

are lengths he is most likely to face from international bowlers in the slog overs. His inclusion at number eight provides only nominal batting "depth", and his skills are wasted late in the innings.

On the balance of his bowling and batting skills, and the relative

